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COMMUNITY CORNER SHAVUOS EDITION



YOM TOV STARTS:

7:56 PM
(18 MINUTES)

YOM TOV ENDS:

9:05 PM
(50 MINUTES)

TZAIS HAKOCHAVIM:

9:26 PM
(72 MINUTES)

Editor-in-chief: Doni Stern

Made possible by contributing writers throughout our community.

STORY OF THE WEEK By: Zechariah Lipitz

When the second Chabad Rebbe, Rabbi Dov Ber (known as the "Mitteler" passed away, there were three prospective successors. Though all three were immensely qualified for the leadership of the Chabad movement, all three unanimously declined the importuning of the Chasidim. These three were: Reb Chaim Avraham, the brother of Rabbi Dov Ber and youngest son of Rabbi Shneur Zalman, founder of Chabad Chasidism, Reb Menachem Nachum, the Mitteler Rebbe's son, and the Tzemach Tzedek, the son of Rabbi Shneur Zalman's eldest daughter. As time passed, the pressure among the Chasidim to find a successor escalated, though it seemed that no solution was in sight. Finally, despairing of a solution being found, two of the Chasidim declared, "It is impossible to be without a Rebbe!" They decided to travel to Ruzhin with the intention of accepting the Ruzhiner Rebbe as their Rebbe. The Ruzhiner Rebbe, Reb Yisrael, was the grandson of the Mezritcher Maggid, and so highly thought of for his enormous piety that he was called the "Holy Ruzhiner." These two Chasidim travelled to Ruzhin for Shavuot. As was the custom there, (as well as among many other Chasidim) the Ruzhiner distributed shirayim - food from his table - to his Chasidim. It was Yom Tov and the Ruzhiner began to distribute wine from his own cup to each of the Chasidim. The two Chabad Chasidim also wanted to participate and receive wine from the Ruzhiner and they proffered their cups for the "cup of blessing." The Ruzhiner, however, refused them, saying, "If you want some wine, you may take it yourself, but I will not give it to you."

The two were very surprised and protested, "Why won't you give it to us, after all we have come here in order to accept you as our Rebbe?"

Upon hearing those words, the Ruzhiner sat down at the table and began to deliver a deep Chasidic discourse based on the theme, "The Giving of the Torah began, not at Mount Sinai, but at the burning bush."

He explained in great depth that when G-d gave Moses the task of taking the Children of Israel out of Egypt, G-d told Moses to "tell the Jews that I have remembered you and want to take you out of Egypt."

Moses' reaction was strange. He replied that he was afraid the Jews would ask him what is G-d's name. To this G-d replied, "Tell them My Name is, 'I will be what I will be.'"

The Ruzhiner posed the question, "Why did Moses ask this question of G-d? For Moses did know G-d's name as he had been handed down a tradition that it was spelled

Yud-Kei-Vav-Kei[1]! And why did G-d answer, 'I will be what I will be.'"

The Ruzhiner elucidated the point through the use of numerical equivalents which are often used to explicate texts. He explained that the numerical equivalent of Yud-Kei-Vav-Kei is 26, while that of the words "I will be what I will be" equals 441 which is "emet" - truth. G-d desired that Moses be able to reveal to the Jews the truth.

"The word 'emet,'" continued the Ruzhiner, "is also an acronym for, 'Torat Menachem Emet' ['the Torah of Menachem is truth']".

When the two Chabad Chasidim heard these words being spoken by the Holy Ruzhiner, they realized that he was intimating that they should return home to the city of Lubavitch and that the Tzemach Tzedek, whose name was Menachem Mendel, should become Rebbe.

Upon arriving in Lubavitch two weeks later, the Tzemach Tzedek had already acquiesced. The returning Chasidim repeated to their fellows the discourse they had heard from the mouth of the Holy Ruzhiner in regard to the word "emet," intimating that the Tzemach Tzedek should be the Rebbe.

The Chasidim recalled with amazement that the Tzemach Tzedek had delivered the same discourse that very same Shavuot, but when he reached the part which identified the acronym of emet with his name, Menachem, he merely hesitated and smiled to himself. Now, they all understood why he had smiled.

COMMUNITY CORNER

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PARSHA QUESTION By: Gavriel Grodtko

Why is the holiday called "Shavuot"?

Stay tuned for the answer in the next Community Corner issue

Answer to last weeks parsha question:

Q. How did the people camp during their travels in the desert?
A. With three shevutim on each side, surrounding the Leveim and the Mishkan.

THIS WEEK IN JEWISH HISTORY By: Avi Hirsch

On May 15, 1902, Jewish housewives on the Lower East Side poured into the streets, breaking windows and throwing meat. The women were protesting a jump in the price of kosher meat from 12 to 18 cents a pound. Food prices were often a source of contention for Jewish immigrant communities in New York. The May 1902 boycott highlighted the ability of Jewish women to organize and coordinate a movement throughout the boroughs. The event made headlines across the city, with some newspapers cheering on the women and others condemning them. In early May of 1902, as the price of kosher meat rose, neighborhood butcher shops stopped selling meat in order to try to force wholesalers, often referred to as the Meat Trust, to cut their prices. The Meat Trust refused to budge and prices remained high. Unhappy with the lack of progress made by the butcher shop boycott, female consumers took matters into their own hands. On May 14, two women organized a meeting on the Lower East Side to rally support for the proposed boycott. The next day, tens of thousands of Jewish women took to the streets and demonstrated their outrage. Riots broke out as women attacked butcher shops and customers. Police officers tried to protect butcher shops, but protesting women grabbed meat and threw it out into the streets, even dousing it in gasoline and setting it on fire. Police arrested 85 people, three quarters of them women. Encouraged by the Lower East Side, women in other neighborhoods began their own boycotts. Protest tactics were not strictly reserved for the streets. On May 17 during Shabbat Torah services, women interrupted prayers with a call to support the boycott. Women left their seats in the balcony to persuade men to back their cause and gain communal support. The press noted the women's impressive organization and strategy. The New York Herald reported that "these women were in earnest. For days they had been considering the situation, and when they decided on action, they perfected an organization, elected officers, ...and even went so far as to take coins from their slender purses until there was an expense fund of eighty dollars with which to carry on the fight." Three weeks into the boycott, the price of kosher meat was lowered by four cents when the Meat Trust agreed to drop prices to 14 cents a pound. Even though prices would rise again, the boycott had mobilized and politicized a group not traditionally involved in organized protest. Unlike most women involved in the labor movement in this period, the women who participated in the boycott were mostly homemakers in their thirties. Although mainly immigrants, most of the women had been living in the United States for many years and were asserting what they saw as American rights—the right to demand fair prices, the right to protest publicly, and the right to speak freely and openly. The boycott would become a model for future protests and was in many ways a precursor to larger scale strikes, including the 1909 shirtwaist strike.

EAST SIDE BOYCOTTERS MEET AND ORGANIZE

Form the Ladies' Anti-Beef Trust Association.

Plan to Establish Co-operative Stores
If Prices Are Not Lowered—Riot-
ers Take a Day Off.

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WEEK 22



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